



**UNIVERSIDAD
DE GRANADA**

Facultad de Ciencias

GRADO EN FÍSICA

Práctica de Complejos

Quantum Chaos and the Statistics of Energy Levels

**María de los Ángeles Lara
Pablo Orellana**

05/2026

Abstract

bla bla bla bla bla bla bla bla bla bla bla bla bla bla bla bla bla bla bla
bla bla bla bla bla bla bla bla bla bla bla bla bla bla bla bla bla bla bla
bla bla bla bla bla bla bla bla bla bla bla bla bla bla bla bla bla bla bla
bla bla bla bla bla bla bla bla bla bla bla bla bla bla bla bla bla bla bla
bla bla bla

Índice

1	Introduction	3
2	Methods	3
2.1	Discretisation of the system: Mascara Method	4
2.2	Finite Difference Method	4
3	Results	5
3.1	Statistical analysis of spacing distribution	5
3.2	High-energy states visualization	7
4	Conclusions	7
	Referencias	7

1 Introduction

The study of complex systems allows to explore the transition between the classical order and the statistical manifestations in the quantum regime. As in classical mechanics chaos is defined as the exponential sensitivity to initial conditions, the linearity in the Schrödinger equation does not allow for a direct translation of this definition to quantum mechanics. However, the phenomena known as 'Quantum Chaos' is manifested throughout the statistical properties of the energy spectrum of the system.

The nuclei in this project is the Bohigas-Giannoni-Schmit (BGS) conjecture, which states that the energy levels of a quantum system whose classical counterpart is chaotic will exhibit the same statistical properties as the eigenvalues of a random matrix ensemble.

To validate this hypothesis, we'll investigate the distribution of spacing between adjacent energy levels in two systems (s_i): one integrable and one chaotic.

The first one is the two-dimensional **rectangular billiard**, which is an **integrable system**. In this system, the random matrix theory (RMT) predicts that the distribution of level spacings follows a Poisson distribution, which is given by:

$$P(s) = e^{-s} \quad (1.1)$$

The second system is the **stadium billiard**, which is a **chaotic system**. In this case, RMT predicts that the distribution of level spacings follows the Wigner-Dyson distribution, which is given by:

$$P(s) = \frac{\pi}{2} s e^{-\frac{\pi}{4}s^2} \quad (1.2)$$

where s is the normalized spacing between adjacent energy levels in both cases.

To integrate the time independent Schrödinger equation for these systems, we will use the **Finite Difference Method** (FDM): this method allows us to discretize the spatial domain and solve for the energy eigenvalues and eigenfunctions of the system.

2 Methods

To be able to solve the Schrödinger's Equation $H\psi = E\psi$, we'll first need to discretize the space and then solve the resulting eigenvalue problem. We'll need to impose the Dirichlet conditions to the domain, which means that the wavefunction ψ must vanish at the boundaries of the billiard.

$$\psi|_{\partial\Omega} = 0 \quad (2.1)$$

All the methods used in this project are implemented in Python, and the code is available in the GitHub repository . To explain the followed procedure, we'll first introduce the Mascara method, which is used to discretize the system, and then the Finite Difference Method, which is used to solve the resulting eigenvalue problem.

2.1 Discretisation of the system: Mascara Method

2.2 Finite Difference Method

Once we have a grid of the system, where $x_i = i\Delta x$ and $y_j = j\Delta y$, being $i = 1, 2, \dots, n_x$ and $j = 1, 2, \dots, n_y$. As we know, the HAmiltonian for a two-dimensional system is given by:

$$H = -\frac{\hbar^2}{2m} \left(\frac{\partial^2}{\partial x^2} + \frac{\partial^2}{\partial y^2} \right) + V(x, y) \quad (2.2)$$

Since in our systems we have a free particle, the potential $V(x, y)$ is zero everywhere inside the billiard and infinite outside. With this consideration, the Schrödinger equation can be rewritten as the Helmholtz equation:

$$\left(\frac{\partial^2}{\partial x^2} + \frac{\partial^2}{\partial y^2} + k^2 \right) \psi(x, y) = 0 \quad (2.3)$$

where $k^2 = E$ (using units such that $\hbar^2/2m = 1$).

Now, we can discretize the second derivatives using finite differences. If we consider one of the dimensions, for example the x -direction, we can approximate the wave function in the nearest points with a Taylor expansion:

$$\psi(x_i \pm \Delta x) = \psi(x_i) \pm \Delta x \psi'(x_i) + \frac{\Delta x^2}{2} \psi''(x_i) \pm O(\Delta x^3) \quad (2.4)$$

Same in the y -direction. If we sum the two equations and subtract them, we can get an expression for the second derivative:

$$\psi''(x_i) = \frac{\psi(x_i + \Delta x) - 2\psi(x_i) + \psi(x_i - \Delta x)}{\Delta x^2} + O(\Delta x^2) \approx \frac{\psi_{i+1} - 2\psi_i + \psi_{i-1}}{\Delta x^2} \quad (2.5)$$

Taking this in consideration, and applying the same procedure for the y -direction, we'll apply the Helmholtz equation in its discretized form 2.6 to the point (x_i, y_j) of the grid.

$$\left(\frac{\psi_{i+1,j} - 2\psi_{i,j} + \psi_{i-1,j}}{\Delta x^2} + \frac{\psi_{i,j+1} - 2\psi_{i,j} + \psi_{i,j-1}}{\Delta y^2} + k^2 \psi_{i,j} \right) = 0 \quad (2.6)$$

Is more efficient to write the resulting equation in a matrix form, where the matrix H is given by:

$$H' = \begin{pmatrix} D & \frac{1}{\Delta x^2} & 0 & \cdots & \frac{1}{\Delta y^2} & 0 & \cdots \\ \frac{1}{\Delta x^2} & D & \frac{1}{\Delta x^2} & 0 & \cdots & \frac{1}{\Delta y^2} & \cdots \\ 0 & \frac{1}{\Delta x^2} & D & \frac{1}{\Delta x^2} & 0 & \cdots & \cdots \\ \vdots & 0 & \ddots & \ddots & \ddots & 0 & \vdots \\ \frac{1}{\Delta y^2} & \vdots & 0 & \frac{1}{\Delta x^2} & D & \frac{1}{\Delta x^2} & 0 \\ 0 & \frac{1}{\Delta y^2} & \vdots & \cdots & \frac{1}{\Delta x^2} & D & \frac{1}{\Delta x^2} \\ \vdots & \cdots & \cdots & \cdots & 0 & \frac{1}{\Delta x^2} & D \end{pmatrix} \quad (2.7)$$

This matrix is called the finite difference matrix (FDM) and it is a sparse matrix, since most of its elements are zero. It has a total of $n_x \times n_y$ elements. The diagonal elements are given by $D = k^2 - \left(\frac{2}{\Delta x^2} + \frac{2}{\Delta y^2} \right)$. The second diagonal elements are going by $\frac{1}{\Delta x^2}$ and it corresponds to the coupling between the nearest points in the x -direction. The elements that are n_x positions away from the diagonal are given by $\frac{1}{\Delta y^2}$ and it corresponds to the coupling between the nearest points in the y -direction.

3 Results

3.1 Statistical analysis of spacing distribution

First, we calculate the first 10000 eigenvalues of each system by diagonalizing the sparse matrix that we obtained applying the DFM 2.7. Then, with those arrays, we compute a new one that has the spacing distribution between consecutive eigenvalues, this is $s = E_{i+1} - E_i$. Finally, we plot an histogram with those, as it follows:

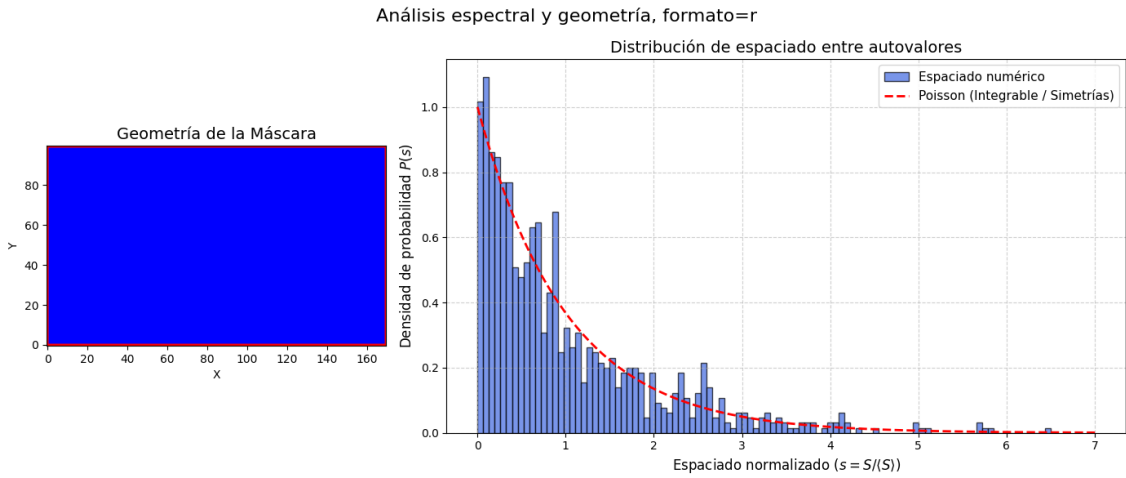


Figura 1: Poisson distribution for the integrable rectangle.

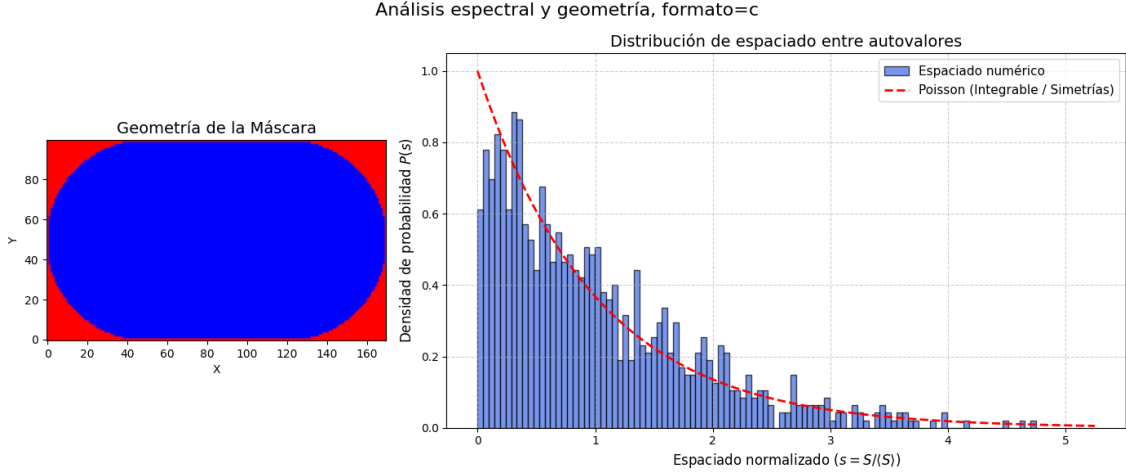


Figura 2: Poisson distribution for the non-integrable complete stadium.

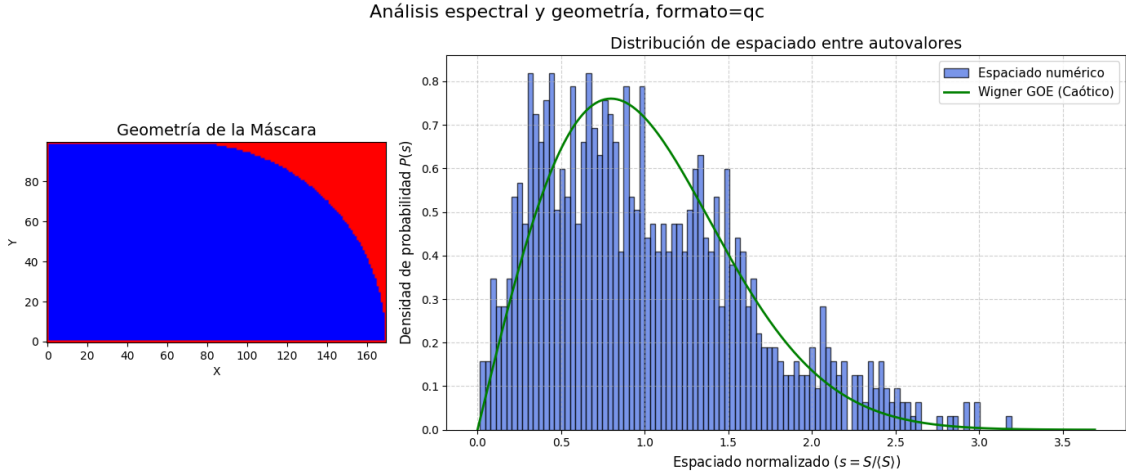


Figura 3: Wigner-Dyson distribution for a quarter of the non-integrable stadium.

As expected, we can clearly see in [Figure 1](#) that the spacing distribution for the integrable rectangle follows a Poisson distribution. This graphic shows how this systems, even if it is integrable, that their eigenvalues are not correlated, then the probability of finding two eigenvalues close to each other is high ($P(s) \rightarrow 1$ when $s \rightarrow 0$). Also, in the case of the non-integrable billiard (the complete stadium showed in [Figure 2](#)), we can see that it also follows a near Poisson distribution, due to the symmetries of the system. This symmetries make the system to have four pairs of solutions, then, the degenerate levels will increase the probability of finding two eigenvalues close to each other, even if the system is non-integrable.

On the other hand, if we eliminate the x - axis and y - axis simmetries, having just a quarter of the stadium as we see in [Figure 3](#), it is noticeable that the spacing distribution for the non-integrable billiard follows a Wigner-Dyson distribution. In this case, the opposite happens: the system may seem chaotic, but its eigenvalues are correlated, in a way that makes them repel each other or, in other words,

the probability of finding two near-degenerate eigenvalues is very low ($P(s) \rightarrow 0$ when $s \rightarrow 0$).

3.2 High-energy states visualization

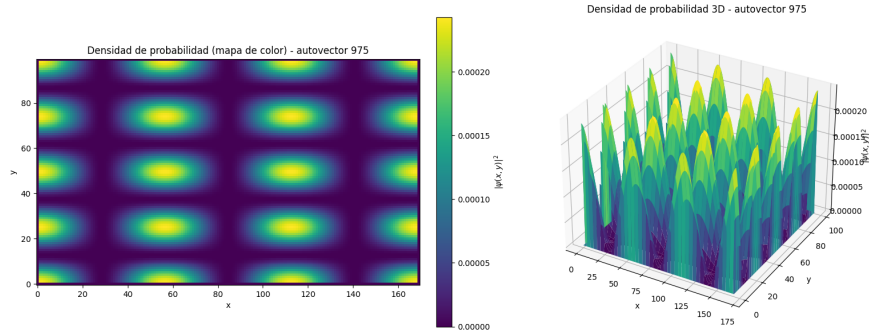
To determine the chaoticity of the system, we must look at high-energy states, and compare them to the non-chaotic system. This is due to the fact that, in the low-energy states, the eigenvectors may seem like those of a string, therefore, they don't contain the necessary information to see if the system is chaotic or not. We then plot the probability density of some of the high-energy states for both systems.

The three graphics of [Figure 4](#) show the probability density for three of the high-energy states of the integrable rectangle. We see that the patterns are very regular, and they look like the fundamental modes of a string, with nodes and antinodes. We can determine then that this system is not chaotic, as expected, since there are periodic patterns in the probability density.

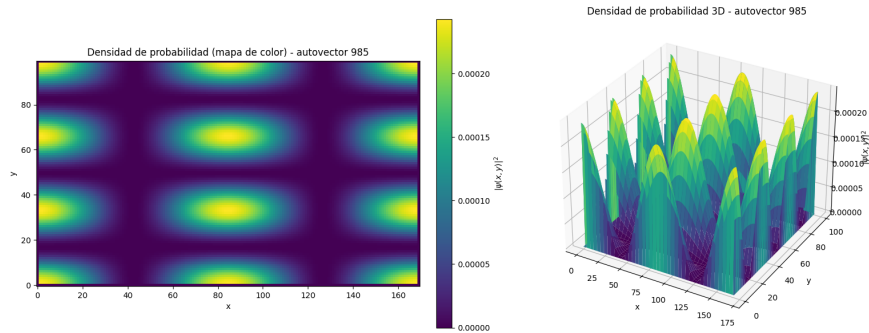
In contrast, the same eigenvalues are shown in [Figure 5](#). It is important to note that we only represented a quarter of stadium, because it is the significant case in our study. In this system, the probability density shows 'quantum scars' or trajectories, which corresponds to classical periodic orbits that a particle would follow within the stadium. Instead of a uniform distribution, these scars represent a quantum localization along specific geometric paths.

4 Conclusions

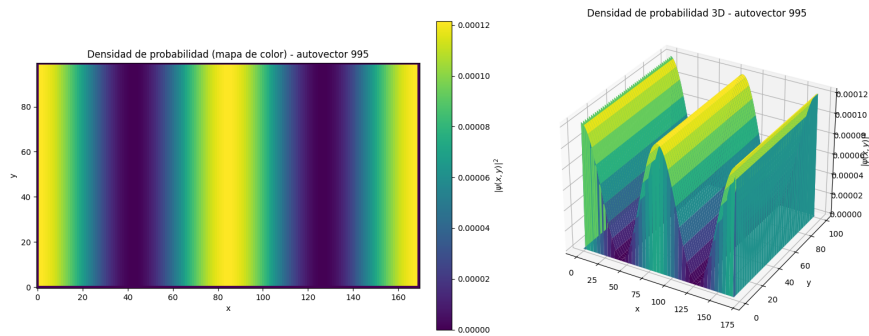
Referencias



(a) Probability density for the eigenvalue 975.

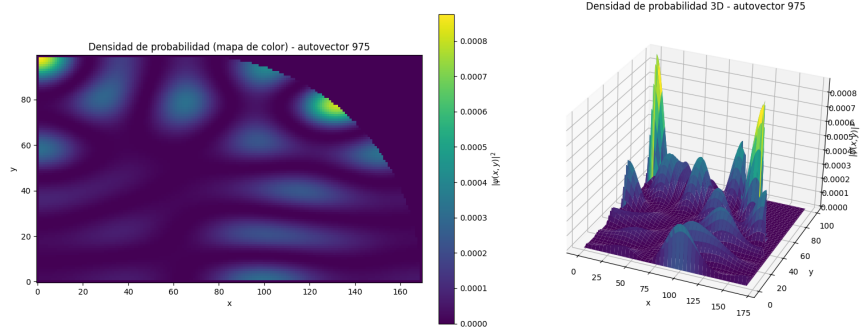


(b) Probability density for the eigenvalue 985.

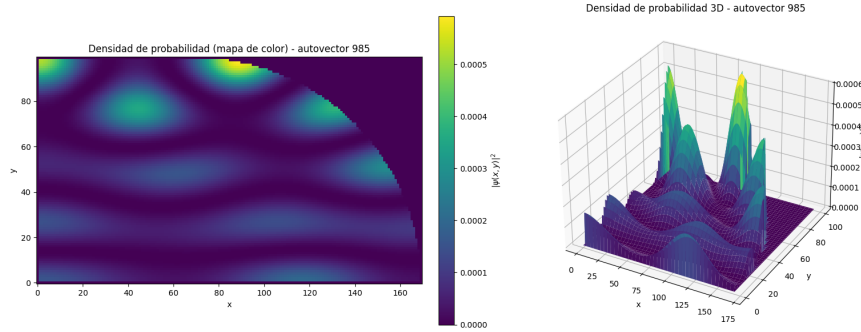


(c) Probability density for the eigenvalue 995.

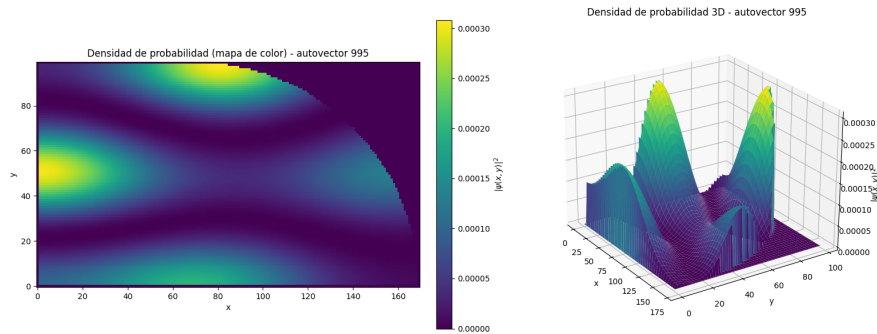
Figura 4: Visualization of various of the high-energy states for the **integrable rectangle**. The probability density is represented in a color scale, where the red areas correspond to higher probability density and the blue areas correspond to lower probability density.



(a) Probability density for the eigenvalue 975.



(b) Probability density for the eigenvalue 985.



(c) Probability density for the eigenvalue 995.

Figura 5: Visualization of various of the high-energy states for the **non-integrable quarter billiard**. The probability density is represented in a color scale, where the red areas correspond to higher probability density and the blue areas correspond to lower probability density.